THE CBI CRACKDOWN

These criminals would have been still engaged in their sadistic games—safe from the law—if the CBI had not been going after a case that shocked even its hardened officers. It was one that kept getting larger, the tracery of evil widening as investigators cleared a path through the jungle with high-end technology and a network of field informers. In November 2021, they formally named it—appropriately, given the grimy archive of evil they ran across—Operation Carbon. It devolved into a countrywide crackdown: 77 locations were raided in 55 districts across 14 states and Union Territories. It resulted in 17 immediate arrests and 23 separate cases against a total of 55 suspects. The CBI also came across foreign nationals, and 46 MLAT (Mutual Legal Assistance Treaties) requests and 269 Interpol references were sent to other countries. Altogether, the agency identified 5,707 participants involved in the sharing of CSAM—2,920 of them foreigners, from 127 countries, and 2,787 Indians whose footprints extend to 24 states.



Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**

But all that began in 2020, in the old-fashioned way—with a little tip-off from a source, and a pen drive containing incriminating evidence. It had been just one year since the CBI had formed the OCSAE unit to investigate cases related to CSAM, and that pen drive led it onto the sordid trail of Rambhawan, the junior engineer in UP's Chitrakoot. It contained 34 videos and 679 photos of CSAM, clearly meant to be sold/ shared over the dark web or niche platforms. Just a cursory scan told the CBI there were enough grounds for a raid on Rambhawan's rented residence in Chitrakoot. What it ran into there was a full devil's workshop—10 mobile phones, two laptops, one digital video recording camera, sex toys, six memory cards, six pen drives, besides over Rs 8 lakh in cash.

Rambhawan—originally from Banda—turned out to be one of the biggest sharks the CBI has netted. The full scope of his satanic enterprise slowly came into view: he had been at it since at least 2012. The victims were all boys, mostly ranging across ages 4-16: nine below 12, one 22 but with a decade of growing up under this shadow. Rambhawan's appetite was abnormal, so proximity and access to victims was key. So was an ancillary fact that shocked the CBI the most: his wife, Durgawati, was an accomplice and facilitator. They were a childless couple, and her presence deepened that tinge of disarming pathos. Close relatives, feeling sorry for their barren lives, freely left their children to spend days with them. Children of domestic help, who could be held in a pincer grip of financial dependence, were also a natural prey base. As were children of poorer relatives for whom Rambhawan was like an indulgent benefactor. Fatherless boys, for whom he bankrolled the essentials like school fees, were particularly useful.

The CBI tracked down 25 victims across Banda, Chitrakoot and adjacent areas that formed an extended playfield for Rambhawan. His confessions uncovered more tools of his craft. He had set up his laboratory meticulously. There were video game consoles like PlayStation, the classic worm on the hook for boys. The multiple mobile phones also came in handy here; the older boys got them as gifts. This line of honey ended at the raptor's claws: spycams, webcams, one Sony Cybershot among them, the works. There were also a series of oil bottles, possessing an unnatural air of menace in the circumstances. "He also bought sex toys online, which he used for his own sexual